Q+A

HIS DARK MATERIALS

ALI FAZAL BRINGS NUANCE TO HIS ROLE AS A COP IN THE PRIME VIDEO SERIES RAAKH, INSPIRED BY THE GEETA AND SANJAY CHOPRA MURDER CASE



Q. You started the year with *Raakh*; *Batwara 1947* is coming up; *Mirzapur: The Movie* will have a theatrical release. Is this what you have wanted all along?
I am excited about how things are shaping up. It has been a refreshing week with the response to *Raakh*. What it has done is appeal to both the cinephiles and the *janta* (masses). It is made in a niche, cinematic style and is also rather dark, so one didn't think it would pick up the way it has. And yes, *Mirzapur* is a big social experiment of 2026 [as it's the first time a web series will get a prequel in the form of a theatrical release].

Q. Jayprakash is such an author-backed character. Is this what an actor craves?
You love it when you get to play to your strengths. I was lucky because I remember I was also prepping to shoot for *Mirzapur: The Movie*, which got pushed. I felt physically I wouldn't fit in to play Jayprakash. Then I read the script and I thought the stakes were far above looks and other surface-level things.

Q. Traditionally, police officers on-screen have this flamboyance. In *Raakh*, there's no *hero-panti*, no monologue, no projection of a persona. He's always playing catch-up...
I agree it could have been played differently. But *jab aap andar kudh jaate hain* (when you are stifled within), there's a deterioration that can manifest in many ways. Within the *vardi* (uniform), the claustrophobia was important to explore.

Q. For many, watching the show has been hard, given the violence and utter moral depravity on display, and the real-life case it is inspired by.
It was heavy for me too, especially seeing it in one go. Watching it in one go was a bit hard. I had to keep pausing and then I just burst out crying when the parents read the poetry. Then the last episode where we touch upon what could have been. It is such a beautiful tribute to the heroism of the victims whom we often forget in the course of the investigation.

—with ***Suhani Singh***

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